

THE GOOD WEEKEND

TRAVEL

Stand by as the get-away becomes a give-away

By KEITH DUNSTAN

THIS IS THE TIME of year when almost everyone you know is heading off to the Northern Hemisphere. There are the 18-year-old females who are setting out with their boyfriends to spend six months in London, Paris and the Costa Brava. Heaven knows how it is done. They tell their parents maybe they will come back this year, maybe they won't.

There are all one's business mates who are setting out on serious fact-finding tours usually financed by the taxpayer. It is fascinating how some of the facts have to be found right at the time of the Los Angeles Olympics.

Then there are the doctors who find it utterly essential to attend medical conferences. They pick hardship times like balmy August-September in hard-ship places like Cannes, Tahiti, Santa Barbara and Lake Como.

Actually there is no need to go to all these spots. I am a brochure collector. On Friday nights at our place when the television is awful we have our Walter Mitty dreams and go very comfortably all over the globe.

The truth is that brochures were never better than they are now. There are at least a dozen airlines in town which are desperate for your custom. For example the Thai brochures are just marvellous: "We fly in a different atmosphere where the intrigue of Thai culture creates exotic airborne pleasures." They've got the Royal Orchid service and there are shots of these slinky Thai hostesses in their long gowns, all wearing orchids on their bosoms.

PanAm coos: "Your patronage is the reason we fly the world... our service was tailored to meet your particular needs for efficiency, convenience and



contemporary elegance. A distinct style that befits your station in life."

PanAm are now providing Sony Walkman headsets. You can torture your ears with almost any exotic tape on earth. Continental are putting in a real, fair dinkum bar, brass rail and all. It will be in the centre of the DC10s and you'll be able to wander up to the bar and order your martini or whatever.

Singapore Airlines are serving their Dom Perignon and Chivas Regal in Waterford Crystal. S.A.S. are fighting back with their pure white dinner

service "made of Feidspar which dates back to the 1800s."

S.A.S. actually have telephones. You can ring up anyone anywhere while aloft. As Groucho Marx used to say: "Is that you Mum? I won't be home for dinner."

There's a fearful battle going on with seats, each claiming to outstretch, outreach the other. KLM reports that their gorgeous seats in Business Class cost \$6000 a piece. Qantas is seat battling as never before announcing they have altered the pitch from 36

inches to 38 inches and giving two inches more leg room.

For those of you who have wriggled, you ought to experience the lovely full pictures of contented dozing passengers stretched right out under divine woollen blankets.

Qantas claims to be the only airline that offers a full scale library aboard. They have tooth picks with dental floss on them, by golly. That's new, and they also offer radio plus a Reuter's news office. You need never be away from the agony of the share market.

perfumes. You tend to smell better if you go first class. In first you get Cartier, Dunhill and Burberry after shave. In Business Class you sink back to Elizabeth Arden.

KLM give you a Delph miniature of the facade of a house containing liqueur plus the toilet bags. Cathay have dreamy His and Hers bags in burgundy. You could take them to the Lord Mayor's Ball. What's more, they have "I'll-slip-into-something-loose" dressing gowns.

I tell you the food and drink battle is awesome. They are all giving drink away now whether you are travelling steerage or the "Royal Sheikh" class. If you are going first class you'll get a glass of French champagne and a flower the second you sit down.

PanAm and Qantas are Moet, British Airways are Veuve Cliquot, Singapore goes for Lanson and KLM for the very expensive Taittinger Brut. The food is beyond belief. We find our Friday night reading of menus particularly frustrating.

British Airways and SAS are pursuing a "Great Chefs" gastronomic struggle. One of the British Airways menus comes from Hermann and Faye Schneider of "Two Faces" in Melbourne. You have to go for stuff like Homard Thermidor washed down by Chassagne Montrachet 1979 or a Contrefilet de Boeuf Roti with a Cotes de Nuits 1980. KLM actually offer five main courses... hare, scollops, guinea fowl, saddle of lamb, fried chicken Szechuan. Lufthansa have a French grand cru wine list which makes going to bed very difficult. Particularly I like the sound of the 1980 Vosne Romanee Burgundy and the 1977 Chateau Pontet-Canet Bordeaux.

Even reading their brochures gives you a case of incurable jet lag. But maybe there's hope. Duncan Harris of Travel World says he was returning to Australia on Continental last Christmas Eve. The Rancun sisters who do their aerobics sessions on TV and radio were aboard.

"We fly in a different atmosphere where the intrigue of Thai culture creates exotic airborne pleasures"

They performed there in the aisles and they had everyone doing exercises in their seats. Well, I called Lisa Rancun in Sydney. She reported that they were providing video programs called "Aerobics" to most of the airlines.

"It's really catching on," she says, "and it makes all the difference how you feel when you arrive." The Rancun sisters do fearful stuff on radio. They get motorists performing in their seats while waiting at the traffic lights. In the airline seats they will give them a routine that will last 15 minutes.

I wonder how those exercises will marry with the fried chicken szechuan and the 1977 Chateau Pontet-Canet.

A cool change is as good as a conversation

EVERYBODY KNOWS that we are having more weather than we used to. It's not just a matter of having lost those long summers of our youth, the ones with the afternoons that seemed to go on forever: there is more mayhem, too. Of course, television now gives all the latest storms from the American midwest. In the global village you not only get global gossip and global bus-accident reports, you get global weather, too.

This is progress. But behind this storm of blizzards, our weather has taken a real change for the interesting: more droughts, more floods, more heat, more cold, an all-round general improvement in weather as a topic of conversation.

And I think I can explain why. The world has become more active. Take Gabon. It may not be widely known that in 1980 this little African republic had no fewer than 9,000 television sets.

No doubt there are even more today, thanks to the sagacious leadership of President Bongo.

Consider the position a decade earlier. In the length and breadth of the country there were hardly 1,000 television sets. A nine-fold increase in 10 years was an extraordinary proliferation, but it still left the Gabonese in 1980 with an average audience of 73 people for every set.

Quite a strain on lounge rooms in prime time, though as I say, the situation might well be less serious today.

My point is this: as goes the land of Bongo, so goes the world. Each Gabonese burned up energy in 1980 at the rate of 1715 kilograms of coal; only fifteen years earlier, it was a paltry 194 kilograms of coal.

A figure like that makes you think. It is surely not hard to see that if we go on at this rate, the weather is bound to be affected.



And for most countries this will be a bad thing. Since for a significant part of the year almost everywhere in the world is too hot or too cold for comfort, more extreme weather will merely increase the danger and difficulty of climate.

BUT AUSTRALIA IS different. Our curse is meteorological moderation, an all-pervading blandness that denies even the tiny nugget of human charity in the Americanism, "have a nice day."

No-one has nice days the way Australians do, except perhaps in the islands (and we know what it does to people there).

We could do with more sharpness, a bit of whip into our winters and scorch into summers.

True, it could hardly be hotter or drier than it is in the Centre, but the Centre's a desert already and if the few people who do live there were forced to move there would be fewer to whinge about how they're ignored by the rest of us.

No, when I'm thinking of a summer with 10 degrees on it, I'm thinking of Sydney.

Pavements melting, power-failures incapacitating air-conditioners and apartment lifts, cars boiling and railway lines buckling: a full, fetid, appalling

New York summer — that would give us some great novels.

There would be an annual exodus south, solving Tasmania's economic difficulties. No-one would ever again contemplate retiring to Queensland.

And winter, a solid, metre-of-snow Liepzig and Kracow winter of blocked roads and blocked radiators, galoshes and grey overcoats and vigorous conversation in brightly-lit restaurants, what an inestimable bonus to Melbourne!

With its bluestone buildings and statues and gardens, Melbourne with a metre of snow would

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gain an aspect of Leningrad, or, in parts, something of the Unter den Linden of Berlin in the 1920s, where it was said of the stone lions at the Brandenburg Gate that they roared every time a virgin over the age of 15 went past.

Snow would do something rain cannot: it would make Melbourne interesting.

We would then have hot-zone writers and cold-zone writers, hot movies and cold movies: a complete climatic range of culture, the way other countries do.

The Russian writers would have been stuck without the snow — what would Tolstoy have written if he lived in Dubbo? — just as the Greens, Conrads and Somerset Maughams inhaled their genius in the tropics.

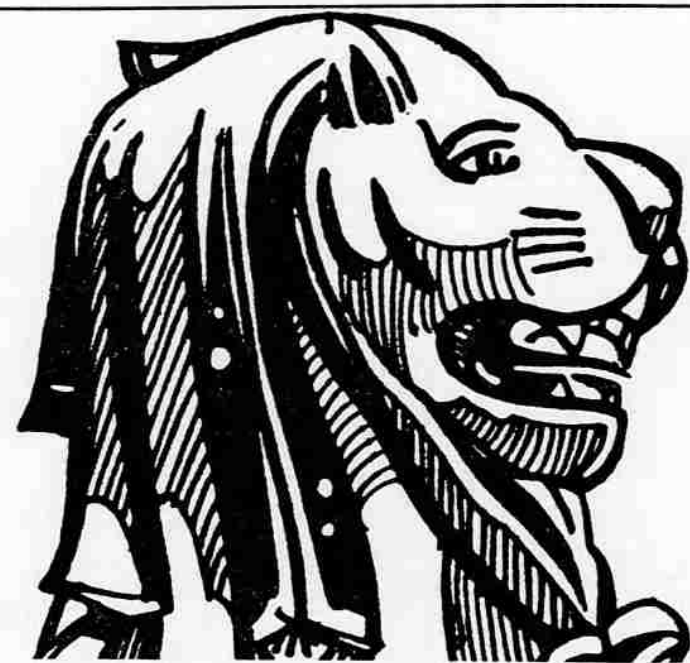
The problem with the weather on the Australian seaboard is that there's too little difficulty in it. We have high-pressures and low-pressures, but the end result is no pressure. It's no worries having a nice day.

It is a different matter inside the continent, but who chooses that in preference to our mild, slip-another-prawn-on-the-barbie suburbia?

No, we will never seek invigoration or difficulty; we will have to be driven to it. And as they stoke up their fires in the Third World and the weather patterns of El Nino become a fixture, not an aberration, we probably will be so driven. The greenhouse is already having its effect.

Is it perverse to celebrate adversity? Well, let's call it pressure, and recognise that it is the missing ingredient in Lotto-land. And don't forget that trouble breeds opportunity.

Like those versatile hot pretzel salesmen who re-emerge on the New York streets in summer selling ice-cream, I intend to open a mint-julep stand in Sydney to complement a Melbourne business selling snow shovels. May we live in interesting climes!



What have Australians got against Singapore?

FOR THE FIRST time in its 20-year history, the Singapore Tourist Promotion Board recorded a drop — 8.5 per cent — in the number of Australians visiting Singapore last year. Significantly, more Australians are visiting Hong Kong than ever before.

In the early 70s, twice as many Australians visited Singapore as visited Hong Kong. By 1980, Hong Kong had caught up.

Hong Kong has two great advantages, both geographic. It is a gateway to the newly accessible People's Republic of China. And it sits on a magnificent harbour and string of islands.

Hong Kong also matches the bargain shopping of Singapore but, unlike Singapore, has kept its exotic, dynamic atmosphere.

Lee Kuan Yew's Singapore has grown antiseptic in recent years. Hong Kong has emerged as the superior competitor for Singapore's Australian tourist market.

Recognising this, Singapore is adapting, studying at what is keeping tourists away.

Australians who visit Singapore frequently will testify to the still-cheap food and taxi fares. What they cannot fail to notice is the change in exchange rate.

In 1978, \$A1 fetched \$S2.65. Yesterday, \$A1 was worth \$S1.89. Singapore bargains are not what they used to be. At the same time, Hong Kong's exchange rate has become more attractive to Australians.

SINGAPORE'S hotel-room rates climbed in the 70s. At the same time, rooms were being built at the rate of 5,000 per year, increasing the supply by about one-third each year. Hotel occupancy rates fell, from 86 per cent in 1981 to 81 per cent the following year.

Some hoteliers are responding with lower prices.

A VIP room at the Mandarin Hotel costs about \$A105 per night. Several years ago the same room cost about \$A165 per night. Mandarin guests are no longer required to pay an additional \$A19 per night to share their room. Regular single and double rooms cost about \$A97 per night.

Other hoteliers are discussing ways of filling their rooms in bulk (attracting groups by giving discounts). But Singapore's greatest problem by

far is its increasingly clinical atmosphere.

Big, new Changi airport could be anywhere in the world. You are driven down well-planned streets at an efficient pace, past high-rise apartments, inhabited and under construction. They grow like the new bamboo of what was once a tropical island.

One jungle still exists. It belongs to the Sultan of Johore. In the block next to the Botanic Gardens, where ducks are on duck ponds, its precious chaos reigns.

Hong Kong is dirty, crowded and fascinating. Singapore is clean. Its markets and street stalls have been replaced by shopping centres or moved into specially planned areas.

The residents are also planned. University-educated women are encouraged by the Government to have three children. Other women are restricted to two. The third child of a

Singapore, home of the fabled Raffles hotel and haven for duty-free bargain hunters, used to be a tourist favourite. But now the exotic image has faded. ALISON CARTMILL reports

EARLIER THIS YEAR 150 people involved in Singapore's tourist trade met to discuss "Marketing Singapore".

One speaker, Dr Wong Kwei Cheong, the Minister of State for Trade and Industry, pointed out that although fewer tourists had been visiting Singapore, their spending had actually increased.

This fact is integral to the Singapore Tourist Promotion Board's new strategy. Singapore is seeking high-yield tourists (for instance, those who spend up big on corporate budgets). So it is being marketed increasingly as a convention centre, particularly for Americans.

In the meantime, retailers are making their own adjustments to corner the tourists who are around.

Johnny Koh, retailer in electronic goods, videos, luggage, watches, jewellery and clothing, said turnover is more

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"less intelligent" mother costs more to be educated than the approved first two.

There are no interesting old cars on the roads. The newer the car and the smaller, the less it costs to register. Even so, a new Suzuki hatchback costs \$3,000 Australian per year to register.

Although it is a port city and once had a river full of junks and flotsam, all but the water has been moved from the city centre to the other side of the island, not easily accessible to tourists. Singapore is efficient. But it is somehow dull, a curiously dead mish-mash of the best of the modern world.

The son of a local businessman told me there was nothing to do in Singapore. He said his favourite place was to the Tiger Balm Gardens, the famous, faded and rather kitsch tourist attraction of larger-than-life figures from oriental legends.

Why? Because the paint is peeling and the gardens are decrepit giving it a beauty like nothing on the island. It is one of the few places left in Singapore with character, he said.

important at the moment than making huge profits.

He advertises his shop by word of mouth. In addition, the green kangaroo logo on his shopfront catches the eye of some Australian tourists.

Some Australians will hear of Johnny Koh before they even leave Australia. He plans to send a representative to Australia later this year to give discount dockets for his shop to Australian travel agents for their Singapore-bound clients.

Cultivating Australian connections is also the practice of Tengah Jewellers in Tanglin shopping centre.

Returned customers and committed bargain-hunters are encouraged to ask for the "best price" on goods. A good deal — and the experience of watching pearls strung while they wait — will bring customers back, the jewellers said, as well as giving them stories to tell about the shop.

The Australian High Commission's Notes on Shopping in Singapore lists shops that provide good service and competitive prices.

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